Since the NDA was designed to train cadets of all the three services, using the terminologies of the army, navy and air force was *de rigueur* in the academy. We found terms of the three services being used in a random mix. At first, it sounded a bit odd to learn that in the drill square there was a 'quarter deck'. Our instructors were amongst the finest officers from the three services. It was common to have a squadron commander from the navy or a battalion commander from the air force. The army cadets were called 'pongos' and the hospital a 'sick bay'! With my army background, I found the whole thing quite funny and confusing at times.

One Sunday morning I was in the barber shop, standing in the queue with a serious look on my face. A senior cadet present there found it very amusing – a Sikh cadet waiting for a haircut.

'Bloody fool (the normal way a fresher was addressed), what are you doing here. Don't you know this is a barber shop?' he barked at me.

'Yes, sir,' said I.

'Then get lost before I make a monkey out of you,' he hissed like a king cobra.

'But I can't do that, sir. I am standing in for Vinod Sir,' was my timid response.

'Disappear immediately, will you? I will sort out your Vinod Sir as well!'

I ran from that area as fast as I could and sought the refuge of my cabin. After that day, I wasn't ever asked by Cadet Vinod (name changed) to do anything stupid.

The daily routine at the academy was very tough. From 6 a.m., when the reveille was sounded, till 10 p.m., when it was lights out, we were kept so busy that we didn't know whether we were coming or going. The day would generally start with PT, drill or equitation. Then, after breakfast, we had classes till lunch. Thereafter, we would have games, followed by a quick shower, and then getting into mess kit for dinner nights or civvies on certain days, and doing self-study before going to the mess for dinner. By the time we returned from the mess, we would be dog-tired and go off to sleep as soon as 'lights out' was announced. The academic curriculum was